



A military art

An American military adviser shows South Vietnamese troops how to kill a communist guerrilla with a bayonet. The ARVN had to match their opponents' tactics and learn new combat skills.

Summoned by bells

The province of Ben Tre, in the southern Mekong Delta, was the scene for one of the first uprisings. As evening fell on January 17, 1960, gongs and bells summoned the locals to rise up against the ruling Diem regime and take control of their villages from the rapacious landlords and corrupt local officials. During the same month at Trang Sup, a village northeast of Saigon, insurgents fought their way into a South Vietnamese Army (ARVN) headquarters and made off with large numbers of weapons. That October, three crack paratroop battalions, hitherto presumed to be among the most loyal of the South Vietnamese units, surrounded Diem's presidential palace. The attempted coup was only narrowly thwarted by forces still faithful to the president.

The insurgents targeted local officials who had the power to imprison for life or put to death any communist opponent of the regime. By the end of 1960, more than 1,400 government officials had been assassinated.